the only legitimate nuclear weapons state in Asia. The Chinese academic and strategic community set about assessing the implications of India's nuclear tests for China in order to build this new narrative. However, there was relatively little up-to-date research on India in the 1990s and early 2000s. A study conducted by a Chinese scholar and published by the Carnegie Endowment for International Peace in 2016, based entirely on Chinese sources about this subject, attests to the paucity of good information on India in general, and India's strategic weapons programme in particular, in the public domain in China. [7] In the absence of original research, Chinese scholars still depended on Western literature.

The handful of Chinese literature that emerged on the Indian Nuclear Question in the early 2000s suggested that India had developed nuclear weapons because it wanted to be a Great Power; and also that she was using the 'China Threat' only to overcome substantial domestic and international opposition to her nuclear programme. The think-tank community remained convinced that despite the diplomatic recovery that India had made after 1998, the United States would never agree to relaxation in the nuclear sanctions imposed by the NSG and, consequently, India's existence outside the NPT regime would continue to marginalize it in international affairs. China could not visualize the possibility of sufficient convergences between India and America that might transcend the American concerns over non-proliferation in order to bring India into the nuclear fold. There was partial truth in all these Chinese assessments, but it did not take into account the changes in India–US relations since President Clinton's visit to India in 2000, as well as the changed internal political dynamics in India since the advent of the first NDA government. Thus, China's policy on the issue of the civil nuclear agreement and its strategy and